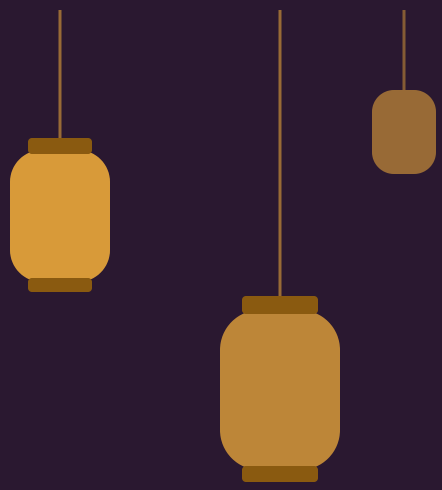
FEATURE OVERVIEW · NOVEMBER 2026



# vn-engine

## and Studio, its editor

A visual novel engine for every genre. Write your story in a plain script, build it with forms and a story map in Studio, and dress it as a romance, a horror story, a mystery, a fantasy journey, a cozy shop sim, a starship drama or a book of letters.

AT A GLANCE

# Everything a visual novel needs, in one place

vn-engine runs your game. Studio is where you make it: write scenes, drag arrows on a story map, set up characters and pictures in forms, and press Play to see the result beside your work. Every feature can be written in script or set up in Studio.

**7**
genre kits that dress the whole game at once

**28**
color schemes, plus your own imported palette

**13**
built-in minigames, set up with plain forms

**1**
readable script language with plain-English errors

## What's inside


1 Writing your story

2 Staging and presentation

3 Built for players

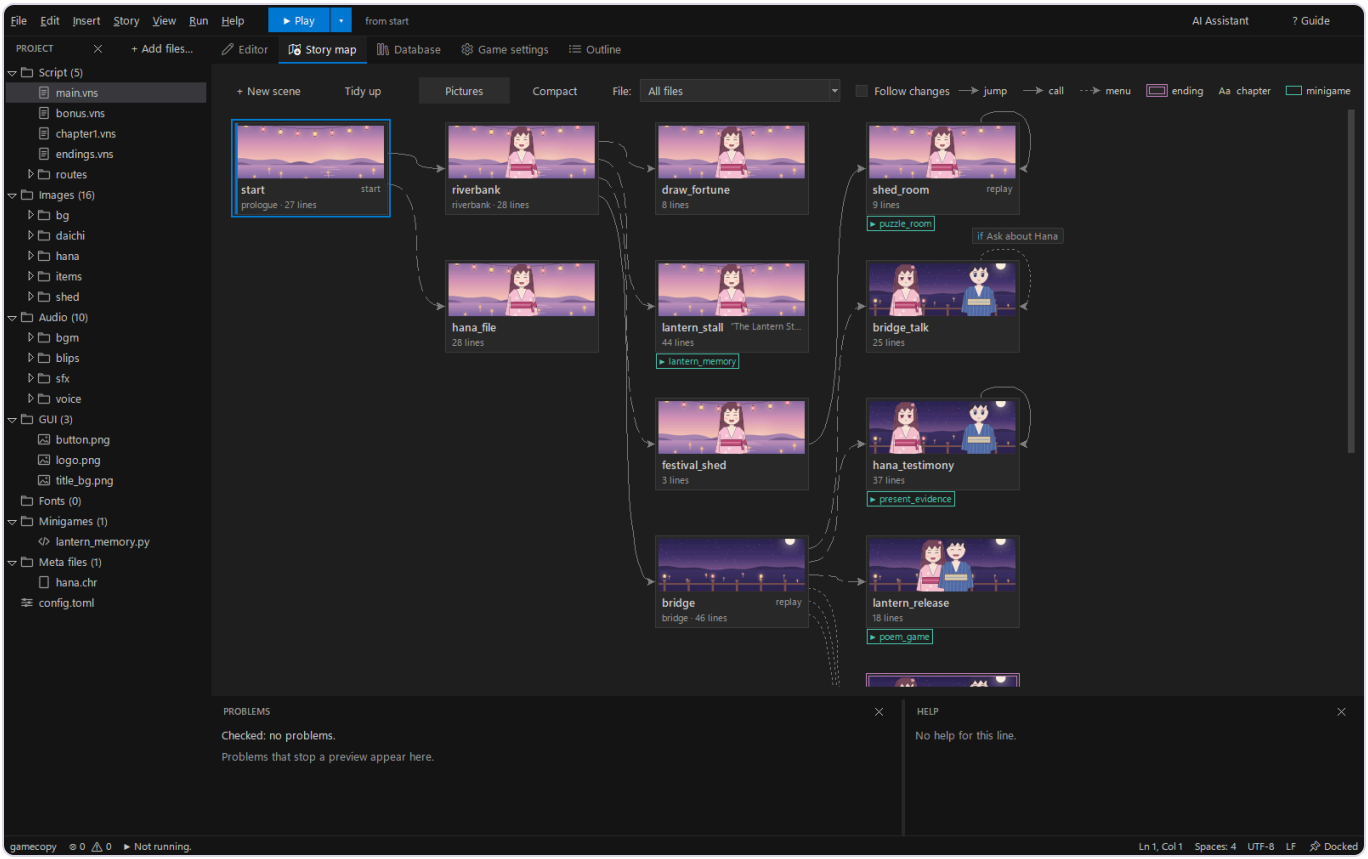
4 Genre systems

5 Built-in minigames

6 Horror and meta toolkit

7 Studio, the editor

8 Testing and shipping


Studio's story map. Each scene is a box showing its opening shot, and arrows show jumps, calls and choices.

1 · WRITING YOUR STORY

# A script you can read aloud

Stories live in `.vns` files. A scene starts with `label`, lines are indented under it, and characters speak by name.

```
# script/chapter1.vns
define hana = Character("Hana", color="#b03070")
points hana 0 to 10 ranks "Stranger" 0 "Friend" 4 "Close" 8
points courage 0 to 10 start 3

label riverbank:
    scene bg river_dusk with dissolve
    show hana happy at left
    hana "You came back. I knew you would."
    menu:
        "Walk her home":
            points hana += 1 "Hana will remember that."
            jump bridge
        "Stay for the lanterns" check courage 8:
            success:
                jump lantern_release
            failure:
                "Your feet stay where they are."
```

### The basics

- Dialogue, narration and inner thoughts
- Scenes, `jump`, `call` and `return`
- Story files split across folders with `include`
- Variables, conditions with `if`, `elif`, `else`
- Python for anything custom, in `$` lines

### Choices

- Menus with conditions, locked options and a time limit
- Stat checks with the odds on the button and a dice roll
- "Show an item" on any menu, with a reaction per item
- Every pick is kept in saves and history

### Mistakes explained

Studio checks the script as you type. Each problem names the line, says what went wrong in plain words, and suggests the fix ("did you mean riverbank?"). New words never break your own variable names.

### Story-wide memory

- Persistent values that survive New Game
- Routes, endings and a true ending unlocked by the others
- Playthrough counts for stories that remember

2 · STAGING AND PRESENTATION

# Put the story on stage

Fixed 1280 × 720 stage that scales to any window or screen, with crisp letterboxing.

### Pictures and characters

- Backgrounds and character sprites with expressions
- Named positions, custom positions and layering
- Blinking and talking-mouth animation that follows the text
- CG pictures that unlock a gallery

### Transitions and effects

- Fade, dissolve, cut and your own transitions
- Screen shake and flash
- Glitches, static and color shifts for darker stories

### Text

- Classic text box with a name tab, or full-page NVL mode
- Typewriter text, inline color, bold, pauses and speed
- Shaking, waving and glitched letters
- Typing sounds per character

### Sound

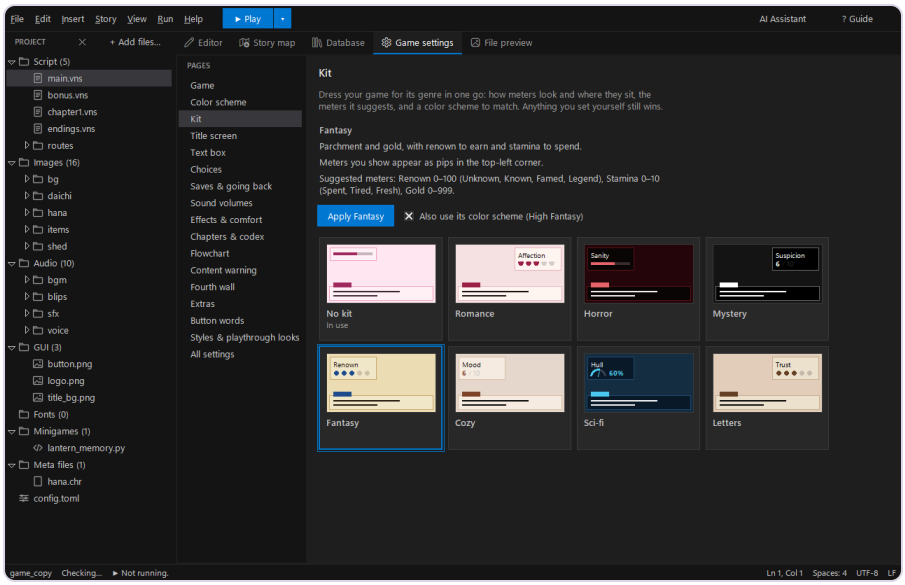
- Music, sound effects and voice channels
- Fades, loops and queues
- Separate volumes for players

### Chapters

- Chapter title cards
- An automatic save at each chapter

### Your look

- 28 color schemes, one click each
- Import a palette from Lospec, Coolors, Adobe or your art program
- Every screen styled from one settings file and your own UI art
- Contrast checked so text stays readable




Game settings ▸ Kit. Each card previews a genre's colors and how its meters look. One click dresses the game.

3 · BUILT FOR PLAYERS

# The comforts players expect

### Saves

- Slots with pictures
- Quick save and auto save
- Slots show story time, like "Day 4, Evening"
- Old saves keep loading after updates

### Going back

- Roll back any line with the mouse wheel
- Pick a different choice
- Step forward again

### Reading

- History with voice replay
- Skip read text, or all text
- Auto mode at your speed

### Extras

- CG gallery
- Music room
- Ending list and scene replay
- Achievements with pop-ups

### Flowchart

- A map of the story so far
- Unseen scenes stay hidden
- Jump back to any visited point

### Codex

- Tips and items players collect
- An Inbox of messages to reread
- Pages named by your genre

### Comfort and accessibility

- Timing assist: slower or no timers in every timed part
- Reduce motion turns animation into simple cuts
- Text size, text speed and window settings
- Content warning before the title screen
- Full keyboard, mouse and gamepad support
- On-screen keyboard for text entry on a gamepad

4 · GENRE SYSTEMS

# One set of tools, dressed for any genre

A handful of shared systems cover most genres. A genre kit gives each one the right words, look and defaults. A fantasy game gets a satchel of gold and pigeon post. A sci-fi game gets cargo, credits and ship comms. Your own settings always win.

| KIT | METERS | STORY TIME | BAG AND MONEY | MESSAGES |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Romance** | Affection as hearts | Thursday, day 4 | Keepsakes · Coins | Phone |
| **Horror** | Sanity as a bar | Night 3 | Supplies | Whispers |
| **Mystery** | Suspicion as a number | Day 4 of the case | Evidence | Dispatches |
| **Fantasy** | Renown as pips | Day 4 of the journey | Satchel · Gold | Pigeon post |
| **Cozy** | Mood as a number | Spring, day 4 | Basket · Coins | Phone |
| **Sci-fi** | Hull as a dial | Shift 2 | Cargo · Credits | Comms |
| **Letters** | Trust as pips | 4 April | Keepsakes · Stamps | Letters |

### Meters players can see

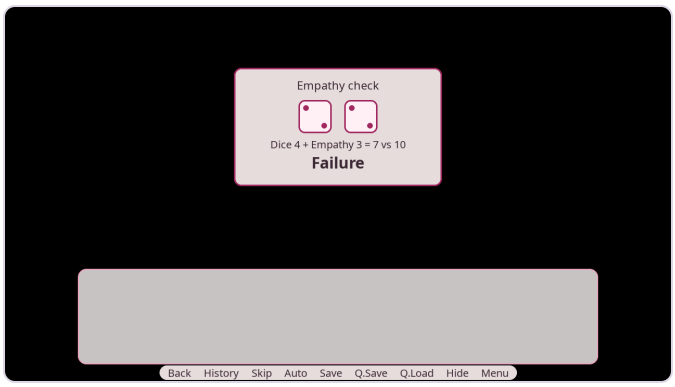
Affection, sanity, suspicion, coins. Give a meter named ranks, show a line when it moves ("Hana will remember that."), and put it in a screen corner as a bar, number, hearts, pips or a dial.

### Checks on choices

A choice can test a stat with two dice. The button shows the odds, a short roll shows the result, and success and failure each lead somewhere. Retry checks come back once the stat changes.




Meters in the status corner: bar, number, hearts, pips and dial.




A check's dice roll, shown before the story continues.

# Time, items and messages

### Story clock

- Days and parts of the day you name
- Weekdays, months and seasons if you want them
- Countdowns to a date
- A day card when a new day starts
- The time in a screen corner

### Items and money

- Items with counts, and one item as money
- A Use button that runs the item's scene
- A hotbar on keys 1 to 8
- A shop where players spend their money
- "Show an item" at any menu

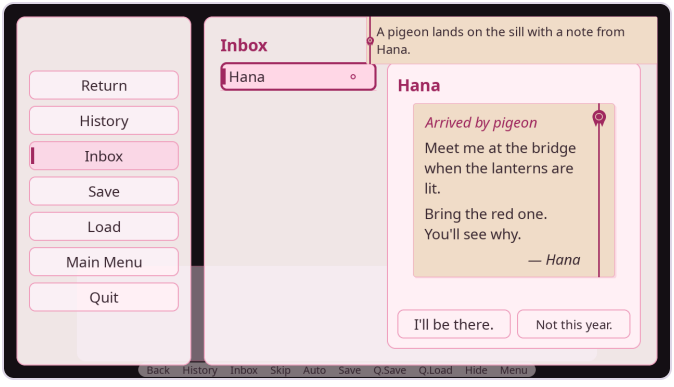
### Inbox

- Contacts and `send` to deliver a message
- Arrival notices in the device's own voice
- Threads to reread, with unread counts
- `open` to bring up the Inbox mid-scene
- Replies at the player's own pace
- Delivery after a day or a few scenes

### Six device looks

Phone chat bubbles, a letter on paper, a pigeon's note with a wax seal, a radio transcript, a green terminal, and borderless telepathy. Each has its own arrival line, and can play a sound you pick. Rename any device in Studio.

```
lock contact hana "Hana" on pigeon
define invite = ["Meet me at the bridge.",
    {"ask": "come", "yes": "I'll be there.", "no": "Not this year."}]
label morning:
    send invite from hana after 1 day
    clock next day
    open pigeon
label festival_eve:
    if inbox.reply("invite") == "yes":
        jump bridge
```




A pigeon note in the Inbox, its arrival notice above, and two replies the player can pick.




The hotbar with item counts, used with the number keys.

5 · BUILT-IN MINIGAMES

# Ready-made moments of play

Each one is set up with a form in Studio and can be skipped by players who just want the story. You can also write your own as a Python plugin.

### Phone chat
A chat with replies that steer the story.

### Present evidence
Pick the item that proves a point, with a penalty bar.

### Puzzle room
Click spots on a picture, pick up and combine items.

### Poem builder
Pick words that appeal to each character.

### Gift giving
Give a held item; each character reacts their own way.

### Shop
Buy items with the story's money.

### Lock
A keypad or dial with a code found in the story.

### Cipher note
Decode a letter with hints learned along the way.

### Terminal
Type commands and passwords into an old computer.

### Heartbeat
Press in time with a pulse to keep your composure.

### Stay still
Don't touch anything. A test of patience.

### Hand game
A quick game of hands against a character.

Plus a text entry prompt for names and answers, in any alphabet your fonts cover.

6 · HORROR AND META TOOLKIT

# Stories that reach past the screen

### Glitches
- Screen tearing, static and color shifts
- Jittering sprites and corrupted text

### Fourth wall
- Change the window title
- A fake crash screen
- Greet the player by their computer name, with permission

### Meta files
- Files in the game's characters folder the story can write, read and react to
- Kept to that one folder

### A game that changes
- Restyle the text box and menus mid-story
- A different title screen on a later playthrough
- Block saving in tense moments

7 · STUDIO, THE EDITOR

# Make the game without leaving one window

Studio is built for writers and artists as much as programmers. Anything you can type in the script, you can also set up with a form, and the two always agree.

### Story map

- Every scene as a picture of its opening shot
- Drag arrows to make jumps and choices
- Updates live as you type

### Events list and stage preview

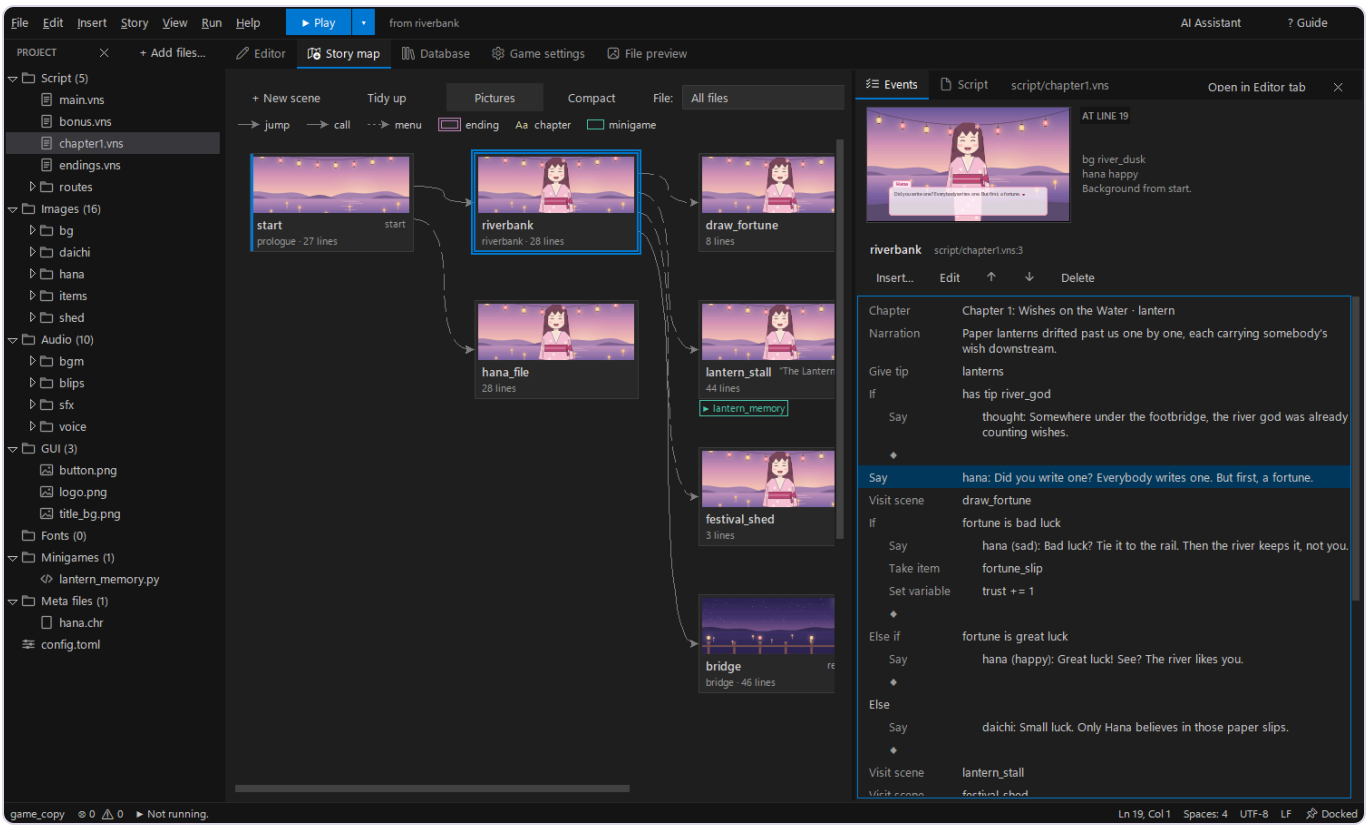
- A scene as a list of readable steps
- Pick any line and see the stage at that moment
- Arrow keys flip through it like a storyboard

### Database

- Characters, pictures, sounds, variables and meters
- Codex, endings, chapters, gifts, shops and contacts
- Ready-made meters from your genre kit
- Write a contact's messages in a chat editor

### Game settings

- Kit, color scheme, calendar, devices, title screen, text box, choices and more
- Live previews in your game's colors
- Every change is one undo step




Pick a line in the Events list and the preview shows that exact moment: background, characters and the line in the text box.

# Write, play, repeat

## Script editor

- Highlighting and checks as you type
- Right-click Go to definition, or Ctrl+click
- Insert menu with a form for every statement

## Play

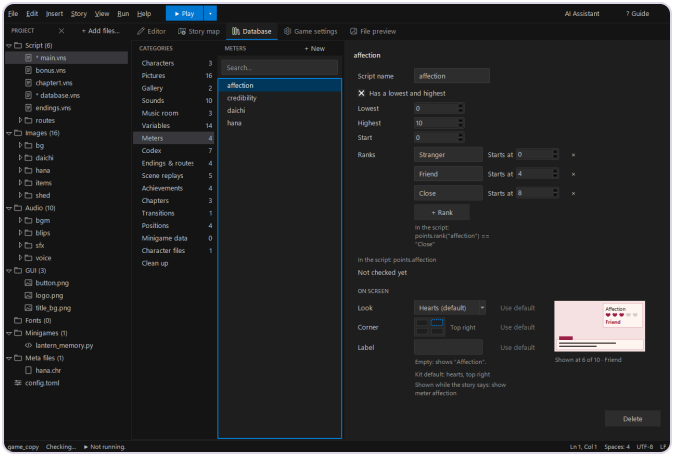
- One Play button that starts from the scene you're in
- The game opens docked beside Studio and follows it
- Save a change and the game updates in place

## Tools for testing

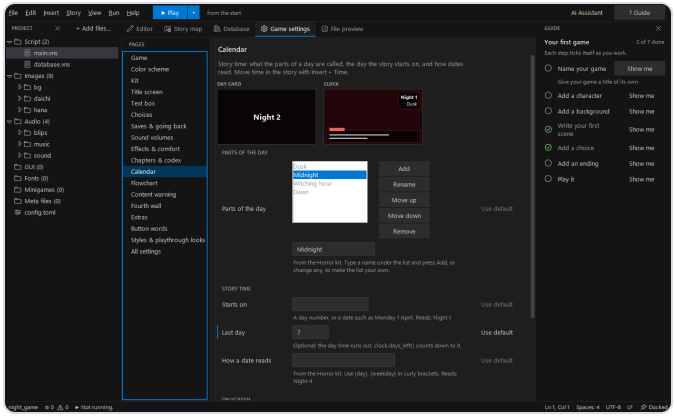
- A developer console to jump to any scene or change a variable
- A Clean up page for unused and unreachable things
- Missing pictures and sounds flagged before you play

## Help on hand

- A Guide that walks you through your first game
- Help for the line under the cursor
- An AI Assistant that can read your game and suggest edits you approve, with your own key or Claude Code



Database ▸ Meters: ranks, the look on screen, and a live preview.



Game settings ▸ Calendar, with the day card and corner clock previewed.

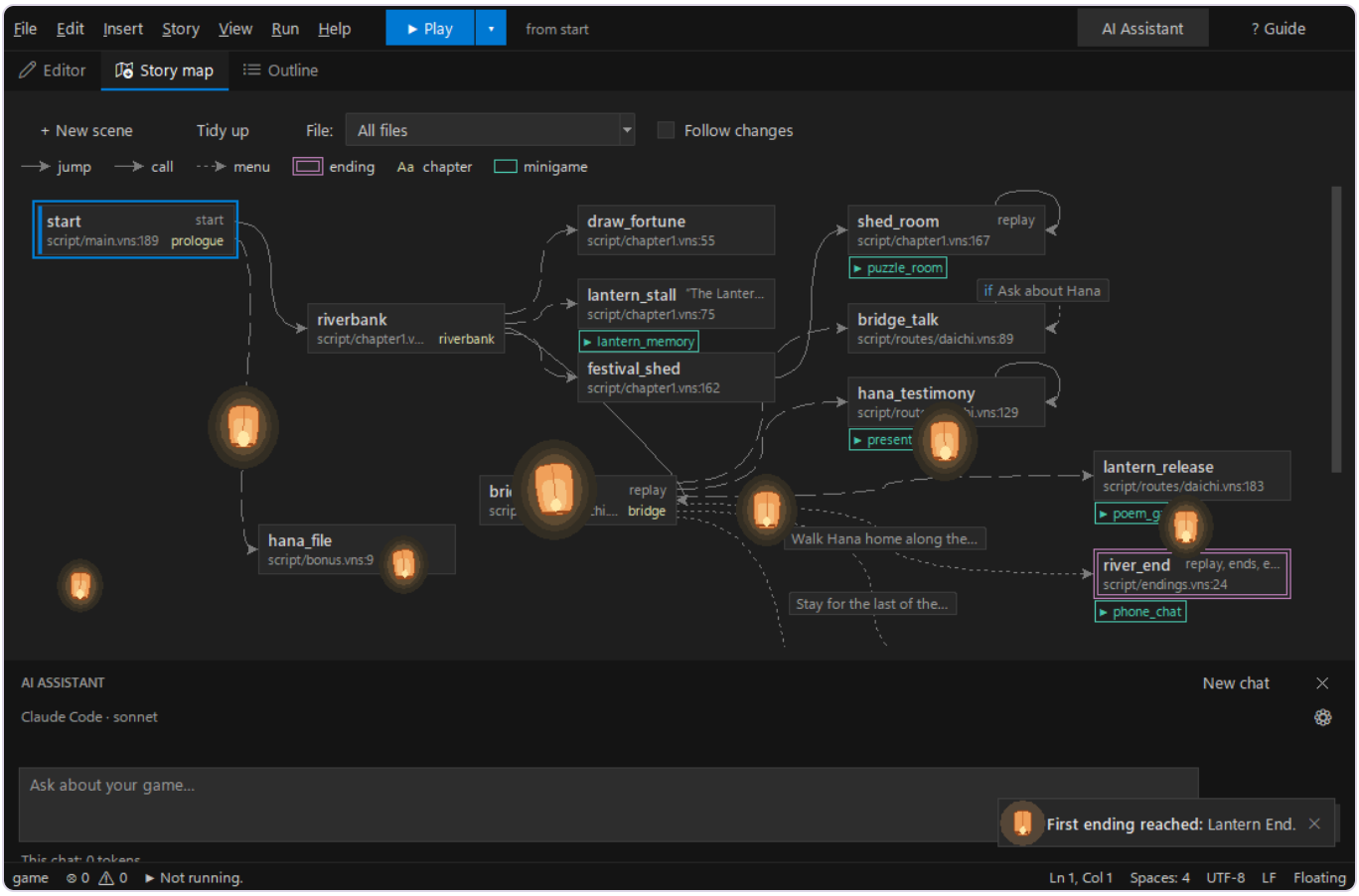
# From first draft to a game people can play

## Build

- Studio's Build makes a ready-to-share Windows game folder and a zip
- Development tools stay out of release builds

## Confidence

- A full check of the script, settings and files
- Scenes and endings no playthrough can reach are flagged
- Saves keep working as your game changes




Studio marks milestones with small celebrations. Here, paper lanterns float up for the first ending a playtest reaches.